to the semis before they were robbed by the idiotic system the ICC used back then to calculate revised totals for rain-interrupted play.

I had a mediocre time with the bat, though, in the 1998 series. It was my second year in the squad and, as a 24-year-old, I guess I was still a little green. As I said, I didn't play in the best-of-three ODI finals against the Aussies, but that's hardly surprising, given my lack of runs in the round-robin games against the Black Caps and the Aussies.

Aside from 54 against Australia A, the only other significant innings I had was scoring 131 in another warm-up game against a Bradman XI ahead of the third and final Test. I didn't crack the nod for the first Test, but played the remaining two. I'd love to say I made a difference, but aside from a 54 in the second Test and a 37 in the final one, I didn't bother the scorers much. We lost the second Test and drew the other two to lose the series 0-1.

So, as all-conquering as we were off the field, we were equally frustrated on it. We also lost the ODI series after dominating matches for all but the final few games, and we should've won the last Test to level the series. About 10 dropped catches and the absence of our fast-bowling kingpin, Allan Donald, didn't help our cause.

Then there was the much talked about incident with Mark Waugh on the final day. He got hit on the arm by a short-pitched delivery from Shaun Pollock, and while walking away from the wicket clutching his arm, his bat knocked off a stump. We appealed. But Waugh was given not out, and rightly so, it must be said. He'd clearly completed his stroke, which meant that he couldn't be given out 'hit wicket'. Then Adam Bacher dropped him the next ball – we would drop Waugh four times in his match-saving innings of 115.

Hansie was seriously pissed off that day. At the end of the match, he speared a stump through the umpire's changing-room door. He was bladdy lucky to get away with a letter of apology.

So ja, not great memories of that trip *on* the field, but wonderful memories off it. We couldn't put a foot wrong when it came to women. In the six weeks we were in Australia, I got to know some gorgeous Australian women as well as they can be known. Yes, Christmas came early for young Herschelle Gibbs that year.

The 'French Evening'